I—Exodus

> ‘The first degree of dutiful obedience is not to scowl with knitted brows when trials befall, but regarding them as the bitter remedies of a physician, to accept them with a cheerful countenance.’
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> – Akbar, Happy Sayings, *Ain-i-Akbari*

Five thousand elephants draped in European velvet and Turkish brocade, hung with chains of gold and silver, lined the road to the newly built stone palaces of Fatehpur. Between every pair of these fluorescent beasts sat a cheetah upon a dais, dressed with equal excess in bejewelled golden collars and rich cloth. Arabian and Persian horses with saddles of gold were part of the spectacle, too; and, lest anyone find it wanting in glitter, oxen carts held up displays of gold embroidery.

The palaces were also decorated, the whole city was festive – as was only fitting. This was Akbar’s city of victory. Only three years since its foundations were laid and, already, Akbar had marched west from Fatehpur and conquered Gujarat, sailed east from Fatehpur and conquered Bihar. Only two decades into his half-century-long reign, and Akbar’s Hindustan was becoming the pre-eminent power in the region, if not upon the globe: the rulers of Iran and Turan had sent envoys to their increasingly formidable neighbour; the Portuguese in Goa, Daman and Diu were ‘submissive’, and possibly of one mind with the Deccani chiefs ‘greatly affected’ by the sheer pace at which Akbar was expanding his realm.[1]

And yet, the elephants in all their finery, the cheetahs in their jewels and the tremendous quantities of gold gleaming in the late October sun were not in honour of yet another military triumph, nor meant to overawe yet another foreign ambassador. The reception had been arranged for a far more humble – you might even say pathetic – audience: the recently widowed, erstwhile ruler of Badakhshan, who had spent the last two decades far less productively than Akbar, nursing a ‘few paltry ambitions’[2] with little success, until he was evicted from the ‘the stony land of his birth’ by his own grandson.[3] This failed and hapless man had been accorded the greatest deference by Akbar’s nobility all the way from the banks of the Indus to the imperial capital, where the glory of his reception so overwhelmed the poor